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Inventor(s)	Patronas; Ioannis (Giannis) et al.

Efficient parallelized computation of a Benes network configuration

Abstract

A routing controller (30) includes an interface (68) and multiple processors (60). The interface is configured to receive a permutation (76) defining requested interconnections between N input ports and N output ports of a Benes network (24). The Benes network includes multiple 2-by-2 switches (42), and is reducible in a plurality of nested subnetworks associated with respective nesting levels, down to irreducible subnetworks including a single 2-by-2 switch. The multiple processors are configured to collectively determine a setting of the 2-by-2 switches that implements the received permutation, including determining sub-settings for two or more subnetworks of a given nesting level in parallel, and to configure the multiple 2-by-2 switches of the Benes network in accordance with the determined setting.

Inventors: Patronas; Ioannis (Giannis) (Piraeus, GR), Bakopoulos; Paraskevas (Ilion, GR), Zahavi; Eitan (Zichron Yaakov, IL), Aharon; Eran (Tel Aviv, IL), Mentovich; Elad (Tel Aviv, IL)

Applicant: MELLANOX TECHNOLOGIES, LTD. (Yokneam, IL)

Family ID: 69005745

Assignee: Mellanox Technologies, Ltd (Yokneam, IL)

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Primary Examiner: Choudhury; Faisal

Attorney, Agent or Firm: Meitar Patents Ltd.

Background/Summary

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS (1) This application is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 17/779,157, filed May 24, 2022, which is U.S. national-phase of PCT application PCT/GR2019/000085, filed Nov. 28, 2019. The disclosures of these related applications are incorporated herein by reference.

TECHNICAL FIELD

(1) Embodiments described herein relate generally to communication networks, and particularly to methods and systems for efficient parallelized computation of a Benes network configuration.

BACKGROUND

(2) Some switching networks support configurable interconnection between multiple inputs and multiple outputs. One type of a switching network having a multi-stage topology is the “Benes network” or “Benes switch.”

(3) Methods for configuring switching networks are described, for example, in a paper by D. C. Opferman, and N. T. Tsao-Wu, entitled “On a Class of Rearrangeable Switching Networks-Part I: Control Algorithm,” published in the Bell System Technical Journal, volume 50: number 5, pages 1579-1600 May-June 1971. In this paper, an algorithm to control a class of rearrangeable switching networks is described, particularly with the base-2 structure. Various methods of implementing this algorithm are also described.

SUMMARY

(4) An embodiment that is described herein provides a routing controller, including an interface and multiple processors. The interface is configured to receive a permutation defining requested interconnections between N input ports and N output ports of a Benes network. The Benes network includes multiple 2-by-2 switches, and is reducible in a plurality of nested subnetworks associated with respective nesting levels, down to irreducible subnetworks including a single 2-by-2 switch. The multiple processors are configured to collectively determine a setting of the 2-by-2 switches that implements the received permutation, including determining sub-settings for two or more subnetworks of a given nesting level in parallel, and to configure the multiple 2-by-2 switches of the Benes network in accordance with the determined setting.

(5) In some embodiments, a processor assigned to the Benes network is configured to determine states of 2-by-2 switches coupled to the N input ports and to the N output ports, and to produce sub-permutations specifying connections required between $N/2$ input lines and $N/2$ output lines of respective subnetworks of the Benes network. In other embodiments, a processor assigned to a given subnetwork having K input lines and K output lines, $2 < K < N$, is configured to receive a K -by- K sub-permutation produced at processing an outer nesting level, to determine states of 2-by-2 switches coupled to the K input lines and to the K output lines, and to produce sub-permutations for configuring $K/2$ -by- $K/2$ subnetworks of the K -by- K subnetwork. In yet other embodiments, the processors include dedicated hardware processors respectively assigned to the Benes network and to the subnetworks of the nesting levels, and a processor assigned to a subnetwork of a given nesting level is configured to communicate sub-permutations for configuring subnetworks of a subsequent inner nesting level via buffers.

(6) In an embodiment, a processor is configured to alternately scan input lines and output lines of the Benes network or of a subnetwork of the Benes network, and to determine states of an input switch coupled to a given input line and of an output switch coupled to a given output line, so that the given input line and the given output line connect to a common subnetwork of a subsequent inner nesting level. In another embodiment, the routing controller includes a marking array, and the given processor is configured to mark already configured input switches and output switches in the marking array, along with their respective states. In yet another embodiment, the given processor is configured to follow a path created by setting the input and output switches, and in response to detecting that the path creates a cycle, to select an input line coupled to an input switch not yet set, from which to continue the scan.

(7) In some embodiments, a processor is configured to determine a first sub-setting for a given subnetwork, for implementing part of a first permutation of the Benes network, and before a full setting for the entire Benes network corresponding to the first permutation is calculated, to further determine a second sub-setting for the given subnetwork for implementing part of a subsequently received second permutation for the Benes network. In other embodiments, the 2-by-2 switches include 2-by-2 optical switches interconnected using optical links, and the processors are configured to determine bar or cross states for the 2-by-2 optical switches so as to route light signals between the N input ports and the N output ports in accordance with the received permutation.

(8) There is additionally provided, in accordance with an embodiment that is described herein, a method, including, in a routing controller that includes an interface and multiple processors, receiving via the interface a permutation defining requested interconnections between N input ports and N output ports of a Benes network. The Benes network includes multiple 2-by-2 switches, and is reducible in a plurality of nested subnetworks associated with respective nesting levels, down to irreducible subnetworks including a single 2-by-2 switch. A setting of the 2-by-2 switches that implements the received permutation is collectively determined, by the processors, including determining sub-settings for two or more subnetworks of a given nesting level in parallel. The multiple 2-by-2 switches of the Benes network are configured in accordance with the determined setting.

(9) These and other embodiments will be more fully understood from the following detailed description of the embodiments thereof, taken together with the drawings in which:

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

- (1) FIG. 1 is a block diagram that schematically illustrates a configurable switching network, in accordance with an embodiment that is described herein;
- (2) FIG. 2 is a block diagram that schematically illustrates a hardware-implemented routing controller for configuring an 8-by-8 Benes network, in accordance with an embodiment that is described herein;
- (3) FIG. 3 is a block diagram that schematically illustrates a K-by-K routing processor, in accordance with an embodiment that is described herein; and
- (4) FIG. 4 is a flow chart that schematically illustrates a method for configuring switches in a Benes network, in accordance with an embodiment that is described herein.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF EMBODIMENTS

Overview

- (5) Embodiments that are described herein provide systems and methods for efficient parallelized computation of a Benes network configuration.
- (6) A Benes network comprises a multi-stage switching network comprising 2-by-2 switching devices. A “switching device” is also referred to herein simply as a “switch” for brevity. Benes networks are rearrangeably non-blocking in a sense that any unused input can be connected to any unused output by rearranging its existing connections. Moreover, the topology of a Benes network typically requires using a smaller number of switching devices than a crossbar topology of the same size. The Benes network topology thus makes a good candidate for usage in optical networks and in on-chip networks.
- (7) A Benes network is typically controlled by a routing controller that configures the switching devices to implement a requested connectivity scheme. Full reconfiguration of the Benes network is however complex, and therefore unsuitable for applications that perform high-rate full reconfiguration of the switching network, such as, for example, microsecond burst switching applications.
- (8) An N-by-N Benes network may be constructed recursively from smaller Benes subnetworks. The N-by-N Benes network itself reduces into two N/2-by-N/2 subnetworks, each of which further reduces into two N/4-by-N/4 subnetworks, and so on. The Benes network is thus reducible in a plurality of nested subnetworks associated with respective nesting levels, down to irreducible subnetworks comprising a single 2-by-2 switch. At a given nesting level, switches coupled directly to the inputs and outputs of the Benes network (or subnetwork) are referred to as input switches and output switches, respectively.
- (9) Consider a routing controller receiving a permutation defining requested interconnections between N input ports and N output ports of a Benes network. The routing controller comprises one or more processors, configured to collectively determine a setting of the 2-by-2 switches that implements the received permutation, including determining sub-settings for two or more subnetworks of a given nesting level in parallel. The routing controller configures the multiple 2-by-2 switches of the Benes network in accordance with the determined setting.
- (10) In some embodiments, the routing controller calculates the setting of the network switches hierarchically, based on the nested topology of the Benes network. At the Benes network nesting level, based on the received permutation, a processor calculates the setting for N/2 input switches and N/2 output switches of the Benes network, and produces sub-permutations required for calculating the configurations of two respective N/2-by-N/2 subnetworks of the Benes network.

Similarly, at a nesting level corresponding to a K-by-K subnetwork, $2 < K < N$, based on a sub-permutation produced at processing an outer nesting level, a processor calculates the configurations of input switches and output switches of the K-by-K subnetwork, and produces sub-permutations for configuring two K/2-by-K/2 subnetworks of the K-by-K subnetwork.

(11) In some embodiments, the processors comprise dedicated hardware processors, respectively assigned to the Benes network and to the subnetworks of the nesting levels. In an embodiment, a processor provides a sub-permutation to a processor assigned to a subnetwork of the next inner nesting level via a buffer.

(12) In some embodiments, a processor of the routing controller is implemented using a Finite-State Machine (FSM). The FSM alternately scans input lines and output lines of the Benes network or of a subnetwork of the Benes network, and determines states of an input switch coupled to a given input line and of an output switch coupled to a given output line, so that the given input line and the given output line connect to a common subnetwork of a subsequent inner nesting level.

(13) In some embodiments, the FSM follows a path created by setting the input switches and the output switches of the Benes network or subnetwork, and in response to detecting that the path creates a cycle, the FSM selects an unmatched input line coupled to an input switch not yet set, from which to continue the scanning. In some embodiments, a priority encoder selects the first unmatched input line within a single clock period.

(14) In some embodiments, the routing controller operates in a pipeline mode, in which calculating switch configurations for the N/2-by-N/2 subnetwork(s) based on a first permutation is carried out in parallel to calculating switch configurations for the N-by-N Benes network for a subsequently received second permutation. Pipeline operation may be applied similarly over multiple successive nesting levels.

(15) In the disclosed techniques, a routing controller configures a Benes network using an efficient hierarchical computation that relies on the nested topology of the Benes network. Moreover, switch settings for multiple subnetworks is carried out in parallel, resulting in fast reconfiguration of the Benes network. The routing controller may be implemented in hardware, e.g., using Field-Programmable Gate Array (FPGA) or Application-Specific Integrated Circuit (ASIC) devices.

(16) The disclosed embodiments are suitable for real-time configuration of Benes networks operating in time-slotted manner in practical applications, including, for example, optical networks comprising photonic/optical switches and on-chip networks.

System Description

(17) FIG. 1 is a block diagram that schematically illustrates a configurable switching network **20**, in accordance with an embodiment that is described herein.

(18) Switching network **20** supports fast routing reconfiguration and may be used in various applications such as optical networks, data centers, on-chip networks that require flexible interconnection among multiple modules such as processing cores, and the like. In an on-chip network, various elements may communicate with one another such as, for example, processor-to-processor, processor-to-FPGA, processor-to-Graphics Processing Unit (GPU) and FPGA-to-GPU.

(19) Switching network **20** comprises a Benes network **24**, coupled to a routing controller **30**. In the present example, Benes network **24** interconnects between a group of eight ports **34** denoted **I0** . . . **I7** and another group of eight ports **38** denoted **O0** . . . **O7**. In practical implementations, however, Benes network **24** may be used for interconnecting between two groups comprising N ports each, wherein N may comprise any suitable integer other than eight. The description that follows refers mainly to an N-by-N Benes network that interconnects between two groups of ports, each comprising N ports.

(20) In the example of FIG. 1, ports **34** are assumed to function as input ports that receive signals from external elements, and ports **38** are assumed to function as output ports that transmit signals to external elements in accordance with the routing configuration of the Benes network. In alternative embodiments, ports **34** and ports **38** may serve as output ports and input ports, respectively. Further

alternatively, each of ports **34** and **38** may comprise a bidirectional port that at any given time may receive or transmit signals.

(21) Depending on the application, ports **34** and ports **38** may connect to external elements (not shown) of any suitable type, such as network nodes, servers, other switching networks and/or devices, and the like.

(22) Benes network **24** comprises multiple switching devices **42**, each of which comprising multiple terminals **44** for connecting to other elements via physical links **46**. Some switching devices such as **42A** and **42E** connect between a port **34** or a port **38** and other switching devices. Other switching devices such as **42B**, **42C** and **42D** connect among neighboring switching devices **42**. Switching devices **42** are denoted S_{ij} , wherein the indices $i=1 \dots 4$ and $j=1 \dots 5$ corresponds to row and column numbers, respectively.

(23) In the description that follows the terms “port,” “input port” and “output port” refer to connections of the Benes network to external elements. The terms “line,” “input line” and “output line” refer to connections to the Benes network via the ports or to connections to subnetworks of the Benes network.

(24) In the present example, switching device **42** (implementing a 2-by-2 subnetwork) comprises a 2-by-2 switch that internally interconnects between input terminals denoted (**TI0**, **TI1**) and output terminals denoted (**TO0**, **TO1**). In some embodiments, switching device **42** is configurable in two possible interconnection states. In a state referred to as a “straight” or “bar” state, the switching device connects between terminal pairs **TI0-TO0** and **TI1-TO1** using internal connections **54**. In the other state, denoted a “cross” state the switching device connects between terminal pairs **TI0-TO1**, and **TI1-TO0** using internal connections **56**. In the description that follows, switching device **42** is also referred to simply as a “switch” for brevity.

(25) In some embodiments, Benes network **24** comprises an optical switching network. In such embodiments, ports **34** and ports **38** comprise optical ports for receiving and transmitting light signals and switching devices **42** comprise 2-by-2 optical switches. A 2-by-2 optical switch routes light signals between two pairs of terminals **44** in accordance with a bar or cross state to which the optical switch is configured. In this case, links **46** comprise optical-fiber cables of any suitable type. In other embodiments, Benes network **24** comprises an electrical switching network. In such embodiments, ports **34** and ports **38** comprise electrical ports for receiving and transmitting electrical signals, and switching devices **42** comprise 2-by-2 electrical switches. Links **46** in this case comprise electrical cables of any suitable type.

(26) An N-by-N Benes network, e.g., 8-by-8 Benes network **24**, may be constructed recursively from smaller Benes subnetworks, down to irreducible subnetworks comprising 2-by-2 switches. The recursive construction thus results in a nested topology of Benes subnetworks, so that a Benes subnetwork of a given nesting level reduces into two (e.g., upper and lower) smaller Benes networks of the following inner nesting level, as described herein.

(27) In the example of Benes network **24**, the 8-by-8 Benes network itself is associated with the first (most outer) nesting level. The 8-by-8 Benes network reduces into respective upper and lower 4-by-4 subnetworks **50A** and **50B**, associated with the second nesting level. Each of 4-by-4 subnetworks **50A** and **50B** further reduces into upper and lower 2-by-2 subnetworks **52**, each comprising an irreducible 2-by-2 switching device **42C**. Specifically, 4-by-4 subnetwork **50A** reduces to respective upper and lower 2-by-2 subnetworks **52A** and **52B**, and 4-by-4 subnetwork **50B** reduces to respective upper and lower 2-by-2 subnetworks **52C** and **52D**.

(28) At the first nesting level, N-by-N Benes network connects between N input ports (**34**) and N output ports (**38**). The Benes network may be partitioned into an input stage comprising N/2 input switches **42A**, an output stage comprising N/2 output switches **42E** and a middle stage comprising two N/2-by-N/2 subnetworks (**50A** and **50B**).

(29) Similarly, at subsequent inner nesting levels, a K-by-K Benes network ($2 < K < N$) connects between K input lines and K output lines. The K-by-K Benes subnetwork may be further

partitioned into an input stage comprising K/2 input switches (e.g., 42B), an output stage comprising K/2 output switches (e.g., 42D) and a middle stage comprising K/2-by-K/2 subnetworks (e.g., 42C).

(30) A 2-by-2 switch in the input stage at some nesting level connects to each of the upper and lower subnetworks of the subsequent inner nesting level. Similarly, a 2-by-2 switch in the output stage at some nesting level connects to both the upper and lower subnetworks of the subsequent inner nesting level. For example, input switch S21 of the 8-by-8 Benes network connects to switches S12 and S32 in respective 4-by-4 subnetworks 50A and 50B. As another example, output switch S14 of 4-by-4 subnetwork 50A connects to S13 and S23 of respective 2-by-2 subnetworks 52A and 52B.

(31) The topology of the Benes network (e.g., 24), allows connecting between any port 34 and any port 38, via a path of multiple switches 42. An example path between port 34 labeled I1 and port 38 labeled O6 may comprise switches S11, S32, S43, S44 and S45, wherein S11 and S44 are set to the bar state, and S32, S43 and S45 are set to the cross state.

(32) Routing controller 30 comprises one or more processors 60 coupled to a memory 64 and to an interface 68 via a suitable bus 72. Routing controller 30 receives via interface 68 an Input/Output (I/O) permutation 76 that defines a requested connectivity scheme between input ports 34 and output ports 38.

(33) I/O permutation may be represented, for example, by numbering the input ports and the output ports in the range 0 . . . N-1. In this case the permutation may be described in a table, wherein a table entry specifies a connection between an input port and a corresponding output port, the input ports are ordered sequentially. Such a permutation is also referred to as a “forward permutation.” An example forward permutation for configuring an 8-by-8 Benes network is depicted in Table 1 below.

(34) TABLE-US-00001 TABLE 1 Example I/O forward permutation for an 8 × 8 Benes network

In	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Out	4	6	7	2	1	3	5	0

(35) In some embodiments, I/O permutation 76 additionally specifies for each output port 38 a corresponding input port 34, wherein the output port numbers are ordered sequentially. Such a permutation is also referred to as a “reverse permutation.” The reverse permutation representation allows fast retrieval of an input port number, given an output port number. An example reverse permutation specifying the same connections as the forward permutation above is depicted in Table 2 below.

(36) TABLE-US-00002 TABLE 2 Example I/O reverse permutation for an 8 × 8 Benes network

Out	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
In	7	4	3	5	0	6	1	2

(37) In some embodiments, routing controller 30 stores the output port numbers of the forward permutation in a memory (e.g., memory 64), wherein the input port numbers serve as memory addresses. Similarly, routing controller 30 stores the input port numbers of the reverse permutation in a memory, and the output port numbers serve as memory addresses.

(38) Routing controller 30 may receive I/O permutation 76 from any suitable network entity such as, for example, a scheduler (not shown) that controls the operation of Benes network 24. Routing controller 30 may receive the I/O permutation via a control plane, e.g., via a dedicated link serving for control purposes. Alternatively, routing controller 30 receives I/O permutation 76 via a data plane. In this case, a data packet carries the permutation information.

(39) Routing controller 30 may receive I/O permutation 76 in accordance with various timing schemes. In an example embodiment, routing controller 30 receives I/O permutation 76 once or updated at a low rate, for long term connectivity. Alternatively, e.g., when Benes network 24 operates in a slotted-time scheme for burst switching (e.g., microsecond burst mode) routing controller 30 receives an updated I/O permutation 76 cyclically, e.g., at a high rate. As will be described in detail below, the routing controller may be implemented in multiple successive processing stages (corresponding to respective nesting levels), in an embodiment. Assuming

operating in a pipeline mode, the period between permutation updates is equal to or higher than the processing time of one (e.g., the slowest) processing stage.

(40) Processors **60** collectively determine a switch setting **80** that specifies bar/cross states to which switches **42** should be set for implementing the end-to-end connectivity defined by I/O permutation **76**. Routing controller **30** configures switches **42** of Benes network **24** in accordance with switch setting **80**.

(41) Memory **64** stores information required by processors **60** in determining switch setting **80**. Such information may comprise, for example, intermediate information passed between the processors in processing the configuration of the Benes network and related subnetworks.

Hierarchical Efficient Computation of Benes Network Configuration

(42) FIG. **2** is a block diagram that schematically illustrates a hardware-implemented routing controller **200** for configuring 8-by-8 Benes network, in accordance with an embodiment that is described herein.

(43) Routing controller **200**, may be used, for example, in implementing routing controller **30** of FIG. **1**.

(44) Routing controller **200** receives an I/O permutation **204** (similar to I/O permutation **76**) specifying the requested connections between input ports **34** and output ports **38**. An example permutation for configuring an 8-by-8 Benes network is depicted, for example, in Table 1 above. In some embodiments, I/O permutation **204** additionally comprises a reverse permutation, e.g., as depicted in Table 2 above.

(45) Routing controller **200** determines a switch setting **208** that implements end-to-end connections between ports **34** and port **38** in accordance with I/O permutation **204**. switch setting **208** (similar to switch setting **80**) that specifies settings of respective switches **42** in the Benes network to respective bar or cross states. Switch setting **208** may be implemented as a table in memory **64**, specifying the bar/cross state for each of the switches S_{ij} , $i=1 \dots 4$, $j=1 \dots 5$. In some embodiments, the bar/cross state is represented as a binary value, e.g., “0” for the “bar” state value and “1” for the “cross” state value.

(46) As will be described below, routing controller **200** calculates switch setting **208** using a hierarchical calculation based on the nesting levels of the Benes topology. In each nesting level the routing controller determines a partial setting, for input switches and output switches of the subnetworks associated with that nesting level, and produces sub-permutations for calculating the setting of subnetworks of subsequent inner nesting levels.

(47) Routing controller **200** comprises multiple routing processors, including a single 8-by-8 routing processor **212**, two 4-by-4 routing processors **216A** and **216B**, and four 2-by-2 routing processors **220A** . . . **220D**. Routing processors **212**, **216** and **220** are arranged and operate in a hierarchical structure in accordance with the nesting levels of subnetworks in the Benes network. As such, routing processor **212** handles the full 8-by-8 Benes network, 4-by-4 routing processors **216A** and **216B** handle respective 4-by-4 subnetworks **50A** and **50B**, and 2-by-2 routing processors **220A** . . . **220D** handle respective 2-by-2 subnetworks **52A** . . . **52D**.

(48) Based on I/O permutation **204**, 8-by-8 routing processor **212** determines an 8-by-8 sub-setting **224** that specifies the setting of input switches **S11** . . . **S41** and output switches **S15** . . . **S45**. For a given port **34** and a given port **38** that are to be connected in accordance with I/O permutation **204**, routing processor **212** sets an input switch and an output switch to which the given input port and given output port are coupled, so that these ports connect via the configured switches to the same 4-by-4 subnetwork. For example, for connecting between **I0** and **O5**, routing processor **212** may set switch **S11** (connected to **I0**) to the bar state and set switch **S35** (connected to **O5**) to the cross state.

(49) In addition, 8-by-8 routing processor **212** produces 4-by-4 sub-permutations **228A** and **228B** as input permutations for respective 4-by-4 routing processors **216A** and **216B**. Sub-permutation **228A** specifies connections between input lines connected to switches **S12** and **S22**, and output lines connected to switches **S14** and **S24** of 4-by-4 subnetwork **50A**. Sub-permutation **228B**

specifies connections between input lines connected to switches **S32** and **S42**, and output lines connected to switches **S34** and **S44** of 4-by-4 subnetwork **50B**.

(50) Each of 4-by-4 routing processors **216A** and **216B** operates in a similar manner to 8-by-8 routing processor **212** but is assigned to a respective 4-by-4 subnetwork. Based on 4-by-4 sub-permutation **228A**, 4-by-4 routing processor **216A** produces a 4-by-4 sub-setting **232A** specifying the bar/cross setting of switches **S12**, **S22**, **S14** and **S24**. Similarly, based on 4-by-4 sub-permutation **228B**, 4-by-4 routing processor **216B** produces a 4-by-4 sub-setting **232B** specifying the bar/cross setting of switches **S32**, **S42**, **S34** and **S44**.

(51) 4-by-4 routing processor **216A** further generates 2-by-2 sub-permutations **236A** and **236B** as input to respective 2-by-2 routing processors **220A** and **220B**, and 4-by-4 routing processor **216B** generates 2-by-2 sub-permutations **236C** and **236D** as input to respective 2-by-2 routing processors **220C** and **220D**. Each 2-by-2 sub-permutation specifies connections between two input lines and two output lines connected to the underlying 2-by-2 switch.

(52) Each of 2-by-2 routing processors **220A**, **220B**, **220C** and **220D** determines, based on received 2-by-2 permutation **236A** . . . **236D**, a respective 2-by-2 sub-setting **240A** . . . **240D**, specifying bar/cross state of a respective 2-by-2 switch **S13**, **S23**, **S33** and **S43**.

(53) The internal structure of a 2-by-2 routing processor **200** (not shown) is typically simpler than that of K-by-K routing processors, $2 < k$, e.g., because the 2-by-2 subnetwork is irreducible and the 2-by-2 routing processors (**220**) need not to produce any sub-permutations. In addition, since there are only two input lines and two output lines, the switch state can be determined using direct logical calculation with no alternate scanning (as will be described in FIG. 3 below).

(54) In the general case, the N-by-N Benes network comprises N/2 input switches and N/2 output switches. The Benes network reduces into two N/2-by-N/2 subnetworks that each further reduces into two N/4-by-N/4 subnetworks, and so on, down to the 2-by-2 irreducible subnetworks.

(55) In some embodiments, dedicated routing processors are assigned to the Benes network and to subnetworks of the nesting levels in various ways. For example, in the embodiment of FIG. 2, a single routing processor (**212**) is assigned to the 8-by-8 Benes network, two routing processors (**216**) are respectively assigned to two 4-by-4 subnetworks and four routing processors (**220**) are respectively assigned to the four 2-by-2 routing processors. In an embodiment, each of the routing processors may be implemented using a dedicated processor **60**, implemented, for example, in hardware. In alternative embodiments, one processor **60** is assigned to process two or more subnetworks of the same nesting level. In general, e.g., in large Benes networks, a single processor **60** may be assigned to process multiple different subnetworks. Reusing a processor **60** in implementing more than one routing processor reduces hardware cost, but typically also slows the reconfiguration rate (e.g., in pipeline mode).

(56) In some embodiments, multiple routing processors process multiple respective subnetworks of the same nesting level in parallel. For example, routing processors **216A** and **216B** receive 4-by-4 sub-permutations **228A** and **228B** and determine the input switch and output switch settings for subnetworks **50A** and **50B** in parallel.

(57) In some embodiments, routing controller operates in a pipeline mode. In such embodiments, routing controller **200** receives an updated I/O permutation **204** soon after routing processor **212** produces sub-setting **224** and sub-permutations **236A** and **236B**, and before the routing controller concluded determining the setting of all switches **42** in accordance with a previously received permutation. In pipeline mode, the routing controller receives input permutations at a high rate and the routing controller requires additional buffering space for intermediate switch settings derived by multiple successive I/O permutations.

(58) In the pipeline mode a routing processor determines a first sub-setting for a given subnetwork, for implementing part of a first permutation of the Benes network, and before a full setting for the entire Benes network corresponding to the first permutation is calculated, further determines a second sub-setting for the given subnetwork for implementing part of a subsequently received

second permutation for the Benes network. In some embodiments, pipeline operation is carried out over multiple successive nesting levels.

(59) In some embodiments, a routing processor provides a sub-permutation to a routing processor assigned to a subnetwork of an inner nesting level via a buffer, as will be described below.

A Routing Processor Implemented in Hardware

(60) FIG. 3 is a block diagram that schematically illustrates a K-by-K routing processor **300**, in accordance with an embodiment that is described herein.

(61) Routing processor **300** may be used in implementing 8-by-8 routing processor **212**, and 4-by-4 routing processors **216A** and **216B** of routing controller **200** of FIG. 2.

(62) Routing processor **300** receives an I/O permutation **304** (similar to I/O permutation **204**) that specifies connections requested between K input lines and K output lines. The routing processor determines a setting **308** for configuring the states of K/2 input switches and K/2 output switches that implements I/O permutation **304**. Moreover, routing processor **300** produces K/2-by-K/2 sub-permutations **312A** and **312B** as input permutations for processing K/2-by-K/2 subnetworks of a subsequent inner nesting level.

(63) In the present example, I/O permutation **304** and each of sub-permutations **312A** and **312B** comprises a forward permutation part and a reverse permutation part. Routing processor **300** stores the forward and reverse permutation parts of I/O permutation **304** in a FWD-permutation buffer **320** and in a REV-permutation buffer **324**, respectively. Similarly, routing processor **300** stores the forward and reverse permutation parts of sub-permutation **312A** in buffers **330A** and **334A**, and of sub-permutation **312B** in buffers **330B** and **334B**.

(64) In some embodiments, buffers **330A** and **334A** (or **330B** and **334B**) in a routing processor assigned to a subnetwork of a given nesting level serve as buffers **320** and **324** of the next inner nesting level. This configuration allows direct forwarding of sub-permutations between routing processors. Note that a routing processor should refrain from modifying the buffer content currently used as input to a routing processor of the subnetwork associated with the next inner nesting level. This may require additional buffering space in pipeline mode, as noted above.

(65) Routing processor **300** comprises a Finite-State Machine (FSM) **350**, which carries out and controls the calculation of setting **308** and sub-permutations **312**. The FSM has access to the forward and reverse permutations in respective buffers **320** and **324**. The FSM additionally has access to forward and reverse sub-permutations in respective buffers **330** and **334**, e.g., via a demultiplexer **354**. The usage of demultiplexer **354** is not mandatory, and in some embodiment may be omitted.

(66) As will be described below, the FSM scans the input lines and the output lines for determining the setting of the K/2 input switches and the K/2 output switches. FSM **350** comprises a marking array **360** for handling switch usage and state. The marking array may comprise an array of registers, e.g., two registers for each input switch and for each output switch. One register serves for marking a switch as “used” or “unused” (or “not yet used”) and the other register stores the bar/cross state of the switch. In some embodiments, the FSM initially marks the input switches and the output switches as unused. When FSM **350** determines a bar/cross state of a given switch, the FSM marks that switch, in marking array **360** as “used” and stores the state determined for that switch in the marking array.

(67) In some embodiments, FSM **350** follows a path constructed along visited input switches and output switches. A cycle in the path may occur, when a path that visits less than the entire input switches and output switches, returns to the starting input switch. When the FSM detects a cycle, the FSM selects an unused input switch for continue the scanning.

(68) In some embodiments, the routing processor comprises a priority encoder **364** that efficiently identifies an unused input line in response to detecting a cycle event. The priority encoder may be implemented in various ways. In an example embodiment, priority encoder **364** identifies the first input line connected to an unused input switch in a single clock period. For example, the priority

encoder comprises a logical circuit that selects the first switch marked as unused in the marking array. In an alternative embodiment, the priority encoder can be replaced by a component that stores (e.g., in the marking array) an index of an unused switch, ready to be used when a cycle event is detected. When this switch becomes marked as used, the priority encoder searches the marking array, e.g., sequentially, for the next unused switch.

(69) Selecting to include (or exclude) a priority encoder external to the FSM presents a tradeoff between speed and available resources. Using a fast priority encoder may reduce the processing delay of the routing processor, but incurs hardware resources, increased power consumption and the like.

(70) The configurations of switching network **20** and routing controller **30** of FIG. **1**, of routing controller **200** of FIG. **2** and of routing processor **300** of FIG. **3** are example configurations, which are chosen purely for the sake of conceptual clarity. In alternative embodiments, any other suitable switching network, routing controller and routing processor configurations can also be used. Elements that are not necessary for understanding the principles of the present invention, such as various interfaces, addressing circuits, timing and sequencing circuits and debugging circuits, have been omitted from the figure for clarity.

(71) Some elements of routing controller **30** such as processors **60**, as well as some elements of routing controller **200** such as routing processors **212**, **216** and **220**, and of routing processor **300** such as FSM **350** may be implemented in hardware, e.g., in one or more Application-Specific Integrated Circuits (ASICs) or FPGAs. Additionally or alternatively, processors **60**, routing processors **212**, **216** and **220**, and routing processor **300** can be implemented using software, or using a combination of hardware and software elements. Memory **64** may comprise any suitable storage element such as, for example, a Random Access Memory (RAM), a Nonvolatile (NVM) memory such as a Flash memory device, or a register array. In some embodiments, memory **64** comprises multiple storage elements of various storage types.

(72) In some embodiments, some of the functions of processors **60**, routing controller **200**, routing processors **212**, **216** and **220** and routing processor **300**, may be carried out by a general-purpose processor, which is programmed in software to carry out the functions described herein. The software may be downloaded to the processor in electronic form, over a network, for example, or it may, alternatively or additionally, be provided and/or stored on non-transitory tangible media, such as magnetic, optical, or electronic memory.

(73) FIG. **4** is a flow chart that schematically illustrates a method for configuring switches in a Benes network, in accordance with an embodiment that is described herein.

(74) The method may be executed, for example, by K-by-K routing processor **300**, for configuring a K-by-K Benes network or subnetwork having K input lines and K output lines. Input lines and output lines may connect to ports of the Benes network or to 2-by-2 switches of subnetworks of an outer nesting level. The method is described as executed by FSM **350**.

(75) At a reception step **400**, routing processor **300** receives an I/O permutation **304**. In the present example, the I/O permutation comprises a forward permutation and a reverse permutation. The routing processor (e.g., under the FSM control) stores the forward permutation of the received I/O permutation in FWD-permutation buffer **320** and stores the reverse permutation of the received I/O permutation in REV-permutation buffer **324**. In an embodiment, before (or in response to) receiving the I/O permutation, FSM **350** marks the K/2 input switches and the K/2 output switches in marking array **360** as unused.

(76) At a scanning management step **408**, the FSM alternately scans the input lines and the output lines of the Benes network in accordance with the I/O permutation received at step **400**. For example, the FSM starts with the first input line connected to the first input switch (e.g., **I0** connected to **S11** in FIG. **1**), and configures this switch arbitrarily, e.g., to the bar state. The FSM alternately configures output and input switches to meet the connections specified in the I/O permutation, as will be described below.

(77) Following step **408**, the method splits into an input branch and an output branch. At an output switch selection step **412**, an input switch has recently been configured, and the FSM selects a corresponding output switch using the forward permutation. At an output switch configuration step **416**, the FSM configures the selected output switch so that both the input line connected to the input switch of step **412** and the output line connected to its matched output switch of step **416**, connect to the same $K/2$ -by- $K/2$ subnetwork of the next inner nesting level. Further at step **416**, the FSM marks the output switch in marking array **360** as “used” along with its configured state.

(78) At an input switch selection step **420**, an output switch has recently been configured, and the FSM selects a corresponding input switch using the reverse permutation. At an input switch configuration step **424**, the FSM configures the selected input switch so that the output line connected to the output switch of step **420** and the input line connected to its matched input switch of step **424** connect to the same subnetwork of the next inner nesting level. Further at step **424**, the FSM marks the input switch in marking array **360** as “used” along with its configured state.

(79) At a sub-permutation updating step **428**, FSM **350** updates sub-permutation **312A** in buffers **330A** and **334A** (or sub-permutation **312B** in buffers **330B** and **334B**) based on the input-to-output connection created by configuring the input switches and output switches.

(80) At a loop termination step, **432**, the FSM checks whether the $K/2$ input switches and the $K/2$ output switches are configured. For example, the FSM checks this condition by calculating a logical AND operation among the 0/1—unused/used marked values in marking array **360**. When the condition at step **432** is true, the method proceeds to a method termination step **436**. In some embodiments, at step **436**, the FSM outputs the bar/cross settings determined for the $K/2$ input switches and $K/2$ output switches, as written in the marking array. The FSM further outputs the sub-permutations written in sub-permutation buffers **330A**, **334A**, **330B** and **334B**. In alternative embodiments, the information in the sub-permutation buffers is accessible for reading by routing processors handling the $K/2$ -by- $K/2$ subnetworks of the subsequent inner nesting level.

(81) When the condition at step **432** is false, the FSM proceeds to a cycle checking step **440**. A cycle event occurs when a path along the configured input switches and output switches (covering less than the entire input switches and output switches) returns to the first input switch of the path. When at step **440** the FSM detects no cycle, the method loops back to step **408** to continue alternately scanning the input lines and the output lines. Otherwise, a cycle was detected, and the FSM proceeds of an input line selection step **444**. In some embodiments, at step **444**, the FSM searches for an “unmatched” input line connected to an input switch that is not configured. For example, the FSM selects the first input line connected to an input switch marked as “unused.” Following step **444**, the method loops back to step **408** to continue the scanning. In some embodiments, the FSM efficiently selects an unmatched input line for continuing the scanning using priority encoder **364**, e.g., in a single clock period, as described above.

(82) In some embodiments, the FSM holds information that describes the physical connections of the 2-by-2 switches among themselves and to input and output ports, within the Benes network. To this end, each of the input ports **34**, output port **38** and switch **42** is assigned a respective number. For efficient calculation of switch configurations to bar/cross state, the numbers used are selected suitable for bit manipulation operations, such as shift and modulo operations, and logical operation such as, XOR, AND, OR operations.

An Example Configuration Flow

(83) Next is described an example execution of the method of FIG. **4**, for configuring 8-by-8 Benes network **24**, e.g., by routing processor **300**. In describing the example, a reference is made to some steps in the method of FIG. **1** above. Consider an 8-by-8 I/O permutation whose first two input-output relations are given in Table 3 below. The I/O permutation contains a forward permutation and a reverse permutation.

(84) TABLE-US-00003 TABLE 3 Two elements of forward and reverse permutation Forward permutation Reverse permutation Input 0 1 . . . Output 2 3 . . . Output 2 3 . . . Input 0 1 . . . The

FSM starts the scanning at step **408** with input port **I0**, which is connected to switch **S11**. In the present example, the FSM configures **S11** to the bar state, and marks **S11** in the marking array as “used” and as set to the “bar” state. Alternatively, configuring the first switch **S11** to the cross state is also possible. In accordance with the forward permutation, input port **I0** should be connected to output port **O2**, which connects to switch **S25**. At step **416**, the FSM calculates the configuration for **S25** as “bar” so that both **I0** and **O2** connect to the same subnetwork **50A**. The FSM marks **S25** in the marking array, accordingly. At step **428**, the FSM updates the forward and reverse sub-permutations to be used for processing subnetwork **50A**. Looping back to step **408**, the FSM uses the reverse permutation to identify that output port **O3** connected to the recently configured switch **S25** should be connected to input port **I1**. Since **S25** is already configured to the “bar” state, **O3** is connected via **S25** to subnetwork **50B**. Moreover, since **S11** is already configured to the “bar” state, input port **I1** is also connected to subnetwork **S25**, thus creating a cycle. At step **440** the FSM detects a cycle from **S11** to **S25** via subnetwork **50A** and back to **S11** via subnetwork **50A**. In response to detecting the cycle, the FSM searches for an unmatched input port for starting another path, at step **444**. For example, the FSM selects input port **I2** connected to unused switch **S21**, and loops back to scanning at step **408**.

Routing Processor Code Example

(85) In some embodiments, routing processor **300**, including FSM **350** is implemented in a Field-Programmable Gate Array (FPGA) using a suitable program written in any suitable coding language for hardware. An example code segment that can be used by the FPGA to configure a scanned switch is given below.

(86) In writing the code, let “int(.)” denote a short version of the logical operator “to_integer(unsigned(.))” used in an actual coding language. The following variables are also used: level_0_col_s-denotes used/unused marking of input switch in the marking array.

level_0_src_idx_col-denotes index of input switch in the marking array. level_0_col_d-denotes used/unused marking of output switch in the marking array. level_0_dst_idx_col-denotes index of output switch in the marking array. level_0_src_idx-denotes index of source (input) line in binary form (e.g., in FIG. 1, index of **I0** is “000.” level_0_dst_idx-denotes index of destination (output) line in binary form (e.g., in FIG. 1, index of **O3** is “011.”

(87) TABLE-US-00004 Code segment: If (level_0_col_s(int(level_0_src_idx_col))(0)='0') and (level_0_col_d(int(level_0_dst_idx_col))(0)='0') then (1) level_0_col_s(int(level_0_src_idx_col))(0)<= '1'; (2) level_0_col_s(int(level_0_src_idx_col))(1)<= '0'; (3) level_0_col_d(int(level_0_dst_idx_col))(0)<= '1'; (4)

level_0_col_d(int(level_0_dst_idx_col))(1)<= level_0_src_idx(0) xor level_0_dst_idx(0);

(88) The code segment given above implements the following composite operation:

(89) If (input switch is unused) and (output switch is unused) then: (1) Mark input switch as used. (2) Configure input switch to “bar” state. (3) Mark output switch as used. (4) Configure output switch to state value (A XOR B).

(90) As noted above, A=“level_0_src_idx” and B=“level_0_dst_idx” denote the binary representation of the indices of I/O couple of lines currently processed. In the expression (A XOR B) at step (4), the Least Significance Bit (LSB) of these indices, indicate whether the index value is even or odd. Note that: (i) Setting any of the input and output switches (**S11**, **S21** . . . **S41**, **S15** . . . **S45**) to the bar state, routes the an even indexed I/O line on the upper subnetwork **50A**, and an odd indexed line on the lower **50B**. (ii) At step 2 above, the input switch is set to the bar state=‘0’.

(91) The XOR result between the LSBs of the indices thus gives the correct configuration of the output switch. For example, for an even index “XX0” (X may be ‘0’ or ‘1’) the output switch is set to “bar” for connecting to an output line having an even index, and to “cross” state for connecting to an output line having an odd index. Code segments similar to the one described above are applicable to other pairs of input line to output line connections when one of the output or input switches is already configured.

Performance Evaluation

(92) Consider an FSM **350** that supports adding two connections in a number N_c of clock periods. For example, in some embodiments, $N_c \leq 5$ clock periods. Therefore, for configuring for all input and output switches of a N -by- N Benes network, the FSM requires $[(N/2) \cdot \text{Math.Nc}]$ clock cycles. For configuring the entire N -by- N Benes network, the clock periods required for calculating the subnetworks settings accumulate. For example, in configuring an 8-by-8 Benes network, the 8-by-8 stage requires $[8/2 \cdot \text{Math.Nc}]$ clock periods, and the 4-by-4 subnetwork stages (executed in parallel to one another) require additional $[4/2 \cdot \text{Math.Nc}]$ clock periods. Counting the 2-by-2 clock periods is omitted because it is typically much lower.

(93) The inventors tested hardware implementation of routing controller **200** in which the routing processors are implemented in FPGAs by “Xilinx.” The FPGA was developed using the “Vivado” Integrated Design Environment (IDE). Specifically, a medium-sized FPGA device of the Virtex Ultrascale family by the Xilinx vendor has been used.

(94) For an 8-by-8 Benes network, IDE-based results indicate that in terms of resource utilization, minimum clock period and overall running time the disclosed embodiments are significantly better than known solutions.

(95) For a 32-by-32 Benes network the inventors made the following rough estimation: (i) Resource utilization using a routing controller (e.g., **200**) in which routing processors **212**, **216** are each implemented, e.g., using routing processor **300**, typically consume only little FPGA resources.

(ii) The run time of the routing controller for the 32-by-32 case, would be on the order of one microsecond, for this category of FPGAs. Even better results are expected in using ASIC devices.

(96) The embodiments described above are given by way of example, and other suitable embodiments can also be used. For example, the embodiments described above mainly address N -by- N Benes networks implemented using 2-by-2 switches. The disclosed embodiments, however, are similarly applicable to other suitable switching networks having a nested or recursive topology. For example, a switching network may reduce into more than two subnetworks. As another example, the inner irreducible subnetworks may comprise crossbar switches larger than 2-by-2 switches, e.g., as in Clos networks, with necessary modifications.

(97) Although the embodiments described herein mainly address routing of Benes topologies for optical switches and optical networks, the methods and systems described herein can also be used in other applications, such as in on-chip networks and backplane interconnections.

(98) It will be appreciated that the embodiments described above are cited by way of example, and that the following claims are not limited to what has been particularly shown and described hereinabove. Rather, the scope includes both combinations and sub-combinations of the various features described hereinabove, as well as variations and modifications thereof which would occur to persons skilled in the art upon reading the foregoing description and which are not disclosed in the prior art. Documents incorporated by reference in the present patent application are to be considered an integral part of the application except that to the extent any terms are defined in these incorporated documents in a manner that conflicts with the definitions made explicitly or implicitly in the present specification, only the definitions in the present specification should be considered.

Claims

1. A routing controller, comprising: an interface, configured to receive a permutation defining requested interconnections between N input ports and N output ports of a Benes network, wherein the Benes network comprises multiple 2-by-2 switches, and is reducible in a plurality of nested subnetworks associated with respective nesting levels, down to irreducible subnetworks comprising a single 2-by-2 switch; and multiple processors, configured to: collectively determine a setting of the 2-by-2 switches that implements the received permutation, including determining sub-settings for two or more subnetworks of a given nesting level in parallel; and configure the multiple 2-by-2

switches of the Benes network in accordance with the determined setting, wherein the multiple processors comprise: (i) a main processor assigned to determine the setting for the entire Benes network by determining states of the 2-by-2 switches that are coupled to inputs and outputs of the entire Benes network; and (ii) a plurality of additional processors, each additional processor assigned to determine respective sub-setting for a respective subnetwork by determining states of the 2-by-2 switches that are coupled to the inputs and outputs of the respective subnetwork.

2. The routing controller according to claim 1, wherein the main processor assigned to the entire Benes network is further configured to produce sub-permutations specifying connections required between $N/2$ input lines and $N/2$ output lines of respective subnetworks of the Benes network.
3. The routing controller according to claim 1, wherein a given additional processor assigned to a given subnetwork having K input lines and K output lines, $2 < K < N$, is configured to receive a K -by- K sub-permutation produced at processing an outer nesting level, to determine the states of 2-by-2 switches coupled to the K input lines and to the K output lines based on the received sub-permutation, and to produce sub-permutations for configuring $K/2$ -by- $K/2$ subnetworks of the K -by- K subnetwork.
4. The routing controller according to claim 1, wherein the main processor and the additional processors comprise dedicated hardware processors, and wherein a given additional processor assigned to a subnetwork of a given nesting level is configured to communicate sub-permutations for configuring subnetworks of a subsequent inner nesting level via buffers.
5. The routing controller according to claim 1, wherein a given processor is configured to alternately scan input lines and output lines of the Benes network or of a subnetwork of the Benes network, and to determine the states of an input switch coupled to a given input line and of an output switch coupled to a given output line, so that the given input line and the given output line connect to a common subnetwork of a subsequent inner nesting level.
6. The routing controller according to claim 5, and comprising a marking array, wherein the given processor is configured to mark already configured input switches and output switches in the marking array, along with their respective states.
7. The routing controller according to claim 5, wherein the given processor is configured to follow a path created by setting the input and output switches, and in response to detecting that the path creates a cycle, to select an input line coupled to an input switch not yet set, from which to continue the scan.
8. The routing controller according to claim 1, wherein a given additional processor is configured to determine a first sub-setting for a given subnetwork, for implementing part of a first permutation of the Benes network, and before a full setting for the entire Benes network corresponding to the first permutation is calculated, to further determine a second sub-setting for the given subnetwork for implementing part of a subsequently received second permutation for the Benes network.
9. The routing controller according to claim 1, wherein the 2-by-2 switches comprise 2-by-2 optical switches interconnected using optical links, wherein the processors are configured to determine bar or cross states for the 2-by-2 optical switches so as to route light signals between the N input ports and the N output ports in accordance with the received permutation.
10. A method, comprising: in a routing controller comprising an interface and multiple processors, receiving via the interface a permutation defining requested interconnections between N input ports and N output ports of a Benes network, wherein the Benes network comprises multiple 2-by-2 switches, and is reducible in a plurality of nested subnetworks associated with respective nesting levels, down to irreducible subnetworks comprising a single 2-by-2 switch; collectively determining, by the processors, a setting of the 2-by-2 switches that implements the received permutation, including determining sub-settings for two or more subnetworks of a given nesting level in parallel; and configuring the multiple 2-by-2 switches of the Benes network in accordance with the determined setting, wherein the multiple processors comprise a main processor and a plurality of additional processors, wherein determining the setting comprises: (i) using the main

processor, determining states of the 2-by-2 switches that are coupled to inputs and outputs of the entire Benes network; and (ii) using each respective one of the additional processors, determining a respective sub-setting for a respective subnetwork by determining states of the 2-by-2 switches that are coupled to the inputs and outputs of the respective subnetwork.

11. The method according to claim 10, wherein determining the setting further comprises producing sub-permutations specifying connections required between $N/2$ input lines and $N/2$ output lines of respective subnetworks of the Benes network.

12. The method according to claim 10, wherein determining a sub-setting for a given subnetwork having K input lines and K output lines, $2 < K < N$, comprises receiving a K -by- K sub-permutation produced at processing an outer nesting level, determining, based on the received sub-permutation, the states of 2-by-2 switches coupled to the K input lines and to the K output lines, and producing sub-permutations for configuring $K/2$ -by- $K/2$ subnetworks of the K -by- K subnetwork.

13. The method according to claim 10, wherein the main processor and the additional processors comprise dedicated hardware processors, and comprising communicating by a given additional processor assigned to a subnetwork of a given nesting level, sub-permutations for configuring subnetworks of a subsequent inner nesting level via buffers.

14. The method according to claim 10, wherein determining the setting comprises alternately scanning input lines and output lines of the Benes network or of a subnetwork of the Benes network, and determining the states of an input switch coupled to a given input lines and of an output switch coupled to a given output line, so that the given input line and the given output line connect to a common subnetwork of a subsequent inner nesting level.

15. The method according to claim 14, and comprising marking already configured input switches and output switches in a marking array, along with their respective states.

16. The method according to claim 14, wherein and comprising following a path created by setting the input and output switches, and in response to detecting that the path creates a cycle, selecting an input line coupled to an input switch not yet set, from which to continue the scanning.

17. The method according to claim 10, wherein determining the setting comprises determining a first sub-setting for a given subnetwork, for implementing part of a first permutation of the Benes network, and before a full setting for the entire Benes network corresponding to the first permutation is calculated, further determining a second sub-setting for the given subnetwork for implementing part of a subsequently received second permutation for the Benes network.

18. The method according to claim 10, wherein the 2-by-2 switches comprise 2-by-2 optical switches interconnected using optical links, wherein determining the setting comprises determining bar or cross states for the 2-by-2 optical switches so as to route light signals between the N input ports and the N output ports in accordance with the received permutation.
